

PORTAL TO PROGRESS
PM Narendra Modi travels inside the Sonamarg tunnel after its inauguration, Jan. 13

KASHMIR/ LADAKH

THE LIGHT AT THE END OF TUNNEL

By Kaleem Geelani

Under the shadow of lofty glaciers in central Kashmir's Ganderbal district, where the winter silence is broken only by the rush of icy winds, a new passage has been carved—one that promises to reshape the fortunes of the region. The 6.4-kilometre Sonamarg tunnel, inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on January 13, not only links the picturesque tourist hotspot—known for its alpine meadows and pristine water bodies—to the rest of India all year round, it is also the cornerstone of a larger strategic vision to reinforce the country's border infrastructure along the Line of Control (LoC) and right up to the Line of Actual Control (LAC), beyond which lies Chinese-controlled territory.

Nestled at an altitude of 8,500 feet, 87 km northeast of Srinagar, this engineering marvel—originally called Z-Morh tunnel—bypasses six avalanche-prone zones on a zig-zag stretch that once cut off access to Sonamarg every winter. With the excavation work on its sister project, the 13.2-km Zoji-La tunnel—located about 18 km further east on National Highway-1—nearing completion, the dream of all-weather access to Ladakh is also closer than ever.

"This tunnel will make the lives of the people of Sonamarg as well as Kargil and Leh much easier," PM Modi announced at the inauguration and emphasised the government's focus on infrastructure development, describing this as a "new Jammu and Kashmir". Year-round access has sparked the J&K government's ambitions to develop Sonamarg as a European-style ski destination. Consultants will be hired for this, says Chief Minister Omar Abdullah's advisor Nasir Aslam Wani. Fiaz Bakshi, vice-president of the Kashmir Chamber of Commerce, says the region's natural ski slopes make it an obvious